

attacks and the packets that were blocked or filtered. With BlackICE, you could even filter the logs in terms of their severity, while other software such as Sygate allow you to view logs of last 24 hours, last week, etc.

Both ZoneAlarm and ZoneAlarm Pro logged the results to a text file, but in the Pro version you had an option to suppress logs for common events such as accessing shares. However, ZoneAlarm restricts the maximum alerts at a time to 500, after which you have to clear the old alerts to receive the new ones.

Pricing, support and documentation

The last parameter under consideration was support, documentation and price. There are firewalls that are free for personal use. This means you can use them at home, but using it in office would require you to purchase a license. Among the 10 firewalls tested, eSafe, Tiny, Sygate and ZoneAlarm are free for personal use. The price of the other firewalls ranged from \$30 to \$50 (approximately Rs 1,400 to Rs 2,300), though PGP was pretty expensive at around \$60 (approximately Rs 2,700). This is because PGP also includes support for digital signatures and VPN.

What is the difference between a free version and a paid one, you may well ask? Apart from the fact that the firewalls are only free for personal use, there is a noticeable difference between the paid software and the free ones, as evident in ZoneAlarm and ZoneAlarm Pro. The Pro version has everything that the free version lacks and even performs better in the intrusion detection tests. There's no instability with ping flooders and IGMP attacks and there are a number of feature enhancements that allow you to customise almost every feature.

However, eSafe really gives you value for money. It ships with an antivirus and a system monitoring utility, and can be tweaked with a bit of difficulty to give very good performance.

Apart from Tiny, the other firewalls came with some documentation and help files. Even NeoWatch had only online support. McAfee had one of the most illustrative guides, while the products from Zone Labs started off with a tutorial. NeoWatch and ZoneAlarm also featured reporting of intrusion attempts to the developers for information.

All the firewalls also offered a feature to update the software—in some cases this was automatic and in other cases you had to manually update from the Web site.

Safety Measures

- Disable File and Print Sharing if you are not going to be on a network.
- Update your antivirus signature files regularly...don't be lazy about it. Use a specialised Trojan cleaner if necessary.
- Regularly apply security patches to your software (especially Windows and IE).
- Don't open e-mail attachments if you don't know what they contain.
- Don't allow unknown applications access to the Internet or to your machine. Use the System Information utility (Start > Accessories > System Information) to check for

- the Running Tasks. To turn off a specific application, you have to edit the registry.
- Regularly check the event logs of your antivirus software or personal firewall.
- Disable ActiveX and Java and uninstall Windows Scripting Host if not required.
- Turn off macros in Microsoft Word and Excel or keep macro protection on.
- Use the command **netstat -a** to check the open ports in your machine. Check the open ports against the common list of Trojan ports to see if Trojans are listening to some ports.

CONCLUSION

To say that there is a proliferation of security-related products these days is an understatement. Major players such as Symantec or Network Associates have a range of suites for the same target audience, each with slightly varying features. For instance, apart from Norton Personal Firewall, Symantec also has Norton Internet Security and Norton Internet Security Family Edition, which extends the firewall feature to include blocking of ads, parental controls, etc.



Similarly, McAfee has McAfee Internet Guard Dog (also in a Pro version), which essentially does the same. The feeling of paranoia, especially in cases of e-commerce transactions and given the number of defacements of Web sites are the primary reasons for such a large number of new software to emerge in this category.

As we said earlier, even in the realms of anonymity, you can be at risk. And if you are not worried about spending around Rs 2,000, then you should definitely go in for a paid personal firewall. **ZoneAlarm Pro** wins easily when compared to the other firewalls.

It did well in all the parameters—its performance was good barring the lack of support for ActiveX controls, it had very good features that were highly customisable and more than anything else, using ZoneAlarm Pro is not at all difficult.

The nearest competition comes from Norton Personal Firewall 2001 (version 2.5). The only area where Norton didn't fare that well was in the SubSeven Trojan detection test. Otherwise, in terms of features it was more than a match for ZoneAlarm Pro with its inclusion of privacy features as well.

But using Norton isn't as simple and that's another area where it lost out. A new version of the Norton Personal Firewall (version 3.0) has been released, and it's quite possible that this version is better than the one we tested, with enhanced performance features.

However, if you want to use a firewall just for personal use, and have a problem with the price, then you can easily use one of the free firewalls. Here, it's a toss-up between **ZoneAlarm** and **eSafe Desktop**. If you can configure eSafe properly, you will get much better performance out of it than what ZoneAlarm will give. Add to this the fact that eSafe comes with its own antivirus scanner, which can be quite useful.

However, don't expect a personal firewall to be a cure for all your problems. There are a lot of precautions you have to take beyond installing a firewall before you are truly in the safety zone. ■